DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

What Was Adam Before the Sin?

Daat Tevunot §126

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §126 (continued)
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 4 May 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: who, what and how

The class continued in the middle of §126, at the foot of page 312. Section 6 looks at evil in relation to man before and after the sin of Adam. There are two kinds of degradation: everything physical coming to an end, to be discussed later, and the lowliness of humanity, discussed now. Adam was created with the ability to sin, and so was imperfect, but that would not have been called lowly had he not sinned. We became low only after the sin.

The effect of our actions on the system depends on three things: who you are, what you are doing, and how. If a great person does something, that is one level; if he is doing something holy, another; and if he does it with awe and the right kavanah, the highest. That is why birds burned over Yonatan ben Uziel as he learned. Or take matzah on Pesah night: one person eats it with full kavanah, another without much thought, but both are eating matzah, so at least one of the three factors is present.

Adam's stature

Now the Ramhal applies this to Adam. Adam was adorned with great holiness. The Midrash says the angels wanted to sing before him. Having been made by God Himself, his potential effect, for good and for bad, was enormous, because of who he was.

This, the Rabbi said, is also why the Gemara (Bava Kama) teaches that HaKadosh Barukh Hu is exacting with His righteous ones to a hair's breadth. It is not because they worked hard and so must be more responsible. It is because, standing so high, whatever they do has a greater impact.

Adam still had to rise

Even so, Adam still needed to rise further. Had he kept his command, he would have been elevated far beyond where he was. What is to come after tehiyat hametim, in the seventh millennium and beyond, could have come at the start, without death. That would have been Olam Haba. This is why Eden is connected with Olam Haba: Eden was meant to become it.

But Adam, though on a far greater level than us, could still fall, which is why he was not perfect. Had he withstood the test, he would have been completed and become eternal.

When he sinned, he not only failed to gain what he should have gained; he also lost what he had, and fell to the level man is on today. "Unfortunately humans sometimes act like animals, and that was only after the sin of Adam."

Three levels

The Rabbi asked the class to work out the three stages of human existence. They arrived at:

- **Level A:** what Adam would have become had he not sinned. This is Olam Haba.
- **Level B:** Adam before the sin, in the middle.
- **Level C:** man after the sin, where we are now.

Adam was at B with the potential to reach A, and fell to C. As learned in Derech Hashem, our service is now twofold: we must go from C to B and then from B to A. In practice it happens in one process at the end, but there is more work. Asked whether Adam was created perfect, the Rabbi said: of great stature, but he had the ability to sin, and he did. In a sense even he was a lowly creature, because he could sin. That is how Hashem made the world.

Ha-adam: humanity

The Rabbi pointed out that in Bereshit the Torah almost always says "ha-adam", the man. We should stop thinking of Adam as a creature just like us walking around. There was a real Adam, but a different kind of Adam: the complete existence of humanity. When we speak of Adam, we speak of humanity as a whole.

The ankle that outshone the sun

The Ramhal brings the Midrash that the heel of Adam HaRishon outshone the sun, and that his height reached from one end of the world to the other, and lists what Adam lost through the sin: his height and his radiance.

Do not take this literally, said the Rabbi. This is exactly what the Rambam meant in his introduction to the Mishnah: people who read the Midrashim simply, out of loyalty to Hazal, actually denigrate them, because the literal reading is absurd. The meaning is that Adam had great stature, and perhaps some physical aspect of that, but a physicality different from ours.

The Ramhal's point is that Hashem makes everything fitting. Adam's physical form matched his spiritual level. "Let us make man in our image": since man stood far above all creatures, God wanted that shown physically too.

Physical and spiritual abilities

Today, the Rabbi said, a person can be in only one place at a time, and needs time to travel. Angels are described as "flying", which means they are swift: whatever Hashem wants them to do, they are already there. Our physical senses are very limited, but our spiritual faculties are not. The greatest of these in this world is the mind: you can sit in England and think about Australia.

A participant asked about kefisat haderekh, the miraculous shortening of journeys. The Rabbi said such things happen, but they are miracles, not the norm. No one after Adam's sin, until

Olam Haba, reaches level B in this world. You can be at the very top of level C, but not beyond.

Eden is not a physical place

On page 320 the Ramhal says that before the sin, the impact of Adam's actions reached the highest levels of the system of cogs, and his body reflected this, close to the level of the angels. Eden, he says, is the place where the angels are now. The Rabbi called this "a very important line": the Ramhal is saying that there is no physical Eden as we imagine it. This would be developed in the next class.

There was no class the following Monday because of a Lag BaOmer event.

Summary

- Adam was made by God Himself and stood so high that his deeds had enormous effect; the greater the person, the stricter the judgment.
- Had he not sinned he would have risen to eternal life, the level of Olam Haba; instead he lost even what he had.
- There are three levels: A, what he could have become; B, Adam before the sin; C, us now. Our service is to go from C to B to A.
- The Midrashim about Adam's size and radiance are not literal; they describe a stature whose physical form matched its spiritual level.
- Eden, says the Ramhal, is where the angels are now, not a physical place as we imagine it.

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